

BEHIND THE BEHAVIOR

WHAT YOUR CHILD'S BEHAVIOR MAY ACTUALLY BE
COMMUNICATING — AND HOW TO RESPOND USING A BODY-
FIRST APPROACH

20 PRINTABLE
REGULATION & BEHAVIOR CARDS



Dr. Caelan Soma

WHEN CHILDREN BECOME DYSREGULATED, THE THINKING BRAIN BECOMES LESS AVAILABLE. THIS MEANS THAT IN HARD MOMENTS, CHILDREN OFTEN NEED SUPPORT, SAFETY, CONNECTION, AND REGULATION BEFORE THEY CAN ACCESS REASONING, LEARNING, FLEXIBILITY, OR PROBLEM-SOLVING.

THESE CARDS ARE NOT DESIGNED TO EXCUSE HARMFUL BEHAVIOR.

INSTEAD, THEY ARE DESIGNED TO HELP ADULTS RESPOND IN WAYS THAT REDUCE ESCALATION, INCREASE CONNECTION, AND SUPPORT LONG-TERM REGULATION AND SKILL-BUILDING.

BEHAVIOR IS OFTEN COMMUNICATION.

WHEN WE UNDERSTAND WHAT MAY BE HAPPENING UNDERNEATH THE BEHAVIOR, WE CAN RESPOND MORE EFFECTIVELY AND COMPASSIONATELY.

ABOUT THE CARDS

THESE CARDS ARE DESIGNED TO BE QUICK, PRACTICAL, AND EASY TO USE DURING REAL-LIFE PARENTING AND THERAPY MOMENTS.

EACH CARD INCLUDES:

- A COMMON BEHAVIOR
- WHAT THAT BEHAVIOR MAY ACTUALLY BE COMMUNICATING
- WHAT NOT TO SAY DURING MOMENTS OF OVERWHELM
- BODY-FIRST RESPONSES
- PRACTICAL WAYS TO HELP
- A NERVOUS-SYSTEM LENS FOR UNDERSTANDING THE BEHAVIOR MORE DEEPLY

HOW TO USE THESE CARDS

YOU CAN:

- PRINT AND CUT THE CARDS
- KEEP THEM ON THE FRIDGE OR IN A THERAPY OFFICE
- REFERENCE THEM DURING DIFFICULT MOMENTS
- USE THEM IN PARENT COACHING
- SHARE THEM IN THERAPY SESSIONS
- SCREENSHOT FAVORITE RESPONSES FOR QUICK REMINDERS

**YOU DO NOT NEED TO RESPOND PERFECTLY.
SMALL SHIFTS IN SAFETY, CONNECTION, AND REGULATION
CAN MAKE A MEANINGFUL DIFFERENCE OVER TIME.**

Slamming doors



MY BODY HAS TOO MUCH ACTIVATION AND NOWHERE FOR IT
TO GO.

WHAT NOT TO SAY

- You're so disrespectful.
- Go to your room.
- Calm down now.

BODY FIRST RESPONSE

- You are really overwhelmed.
- Let's help your body settle.

WHAT HELPS

- movement
- physical release
- reduced talking
- co-regulation
- later repair conversation

NERVOUS SYSTEM LENS

Big body movements are often signs of nervous system overload, not just intentional defiance.

Refusing school



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SCHOOL FEELS EMOTIONALLY, SOCIALLY, OR PHYSICALLY
OVERWHELMING

WHAT NOT TO SAY

- You're being lazy.
- We all have to do things we don't want to do.

BODY FIRST RESPONSE

- Your body is overwhelmed.
- Something about school feels hard.

WHAT HELPS

- reducing shame
- predictable routines
- collaborative problem-solving
- sensory supports
- gradual exposure

NERVOUS SYSTEM LENS

When stress systems stay activated, the brain prioritizes protection over learning, flexibility, and participation.

I don't care!



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I CARE SO MUCH THAT SHUTTING DOWN FEELS SAFER.

WHAT NOT TO SAY

- Fine! Then don't care.
- You are impossible.

BODY FIRST RESPONSE

- Sometimes people say that when things feel really big.
- I'm still here with you.

WHAT HELPS

- reducing pressure
- emotional safety
- curiosity instead of confrontation
- slowing conversations

NERVOUS SYSTEM LENS

Shutdown responses often protect children from overwhelm, disappointment, shame, or vulnerability.

Hitting sibling



MY NERVOUS SYSTEM LOST CONTROL BEFORE MY THINKING
BRAIN COULD STEP IN.

WHAT NOT TO SAY

- What is wrong with you?
- You are mean.
- Go away.

BODY FIRST RESPONSE

- I'm going to help everyone get calm and safe.
- Your body got too unsafe.

WHAT HELPS

- immediate safety
- calm containment
- movement
- sensory regulation
- later teaching after calm

NERVOUS SYSTEM LENS

Aggression often happens when the survival brain overrides the thinking brain.

Hiding in bedroom



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MY NERVOUS SYSTEM NEEDS LESS STIMULATION AND MORE PROTECTION

WHAT NOT TO SAY

- Stop isolating.
- You're being rude.
- Come out of there right now.

BODY FIRST RESPONSE

- Your body needs some space and quiet.

WHAT HELPS

- low-pressure connection
- snacks/drinks nearby
- quiet presence
- gentle check-ins

NERVOUS SYSTEM LENS

Withdrawal can be a nervous system attempt to reduce overwhelm, not necessarily rejection

IMPORTANT NOTE

THIS RESOURCE IS EDUCATIONAL IN NATURE AND IS NOT A
SUBSTITUTE FOR THERAPY, MEDICAL CARE, OR
INDIVIDUALIZED MENTAL HEALTH TREATMENT.
EVERY CHILD IS DIFFERENT.

NOT EVERY BEHAVIOR REFLECTS NERVOUS SYSTEM
DYSREGULATION, AND BEHAVIOR SHOULD ALWAYS BE
CONSIDERED WITHIN THE CONTEXT OF DEVELOPMENT,
ENVIRONMENT, RELATIONSHIPS, SENSORY NEEDS, LEARNING
DIFFERENCES, STRESS, AND LIVED EXPERIENCES.

THESE CARDS ARE DESIGNED TO SUPPORT UNDERSTANDING,
CONNECTION, AND REGULATION-BASED RESPONSES — NOT
PERFECTION.

A FINAL REMINDER

CHILDREN DO WELL WHEN THEY CAN.
MANY BEHAVIORS THAT LOOK “DIFFICULT” ON THE OUTSIDE
MAY REFLECT OVERWHELM, STRESS, FEAR, EXHAUSTION,
DISCONNECTION, SENSORY OVERLOAD, OR NERVOUS SYSTEM
DYSREGULATION UNDERNEATH.

CONNECTION AND REGULATION DO NOT REMOVE
BOUNDARIES.

THEY HELP CHILDREN ACCESS THE BRAIN STATES NEEDED
FOR LEARNING, FLEXIBILITY, ACCOUNTABILITY, AND GROWTH.

BEHAVIOR IS OFTEN COMMUNICATION.

DR. CAELAN SOMA

CONTINUE LEARNING

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**PODCAST
BODY FIRST WITH DR. CAELAN SOMA**

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